THE NAME BEFORE

A HISTORICAL ONE-SHOT

12 April 1912
RMS Titanic

An original work of historical fiction

I

Before she fell, Lorraine noticed that the officer had lost a button from his glove.

It was a ridiculous thing to take into unconsciousness. His face she could have excused; she had carried it into sleep often enough, sometimes without invitation. But the pale rim of a buttonhole, the leather opening a little at his wrist: that was what remained when the deck tipped and the Atlantic came up through the soles of her shoes.

She did not remember striking the boards. Afterwards there was a pain above her ear, no worse than a hairpin driven carelessly home. Her hat had saved her, somebody said. An expensive argument for hats.

She returned to a circle of shoes. Her husband's brown walking shoes were nearest, beautifully polished and standing too far apart. Edmund's were moving. Her son had never yet encountered a calamity he could not improve by changing position. Beside them stood the black shoes of an officer, and above those, knees, a gold stripe, the white edge of a collar.

“Give her room, please.”

For twenty years she had preserved his voice incorrectly. She had kept it young. This one had acquired a little gravel and the authority of a man accustomed to being obeyed before he explained himself.

“Lorraine.”

That was her husband.

She opened her eyes entirely. The sky above the promenade was without character, a thin working sky. A steward knelt with water. Frances had removed one glove

and was holding Lorraine's hand with an expression of stern disgust, as though her mother had committed a social fault which the daughter would now have to repair.

“I am quite well,” Lorraine said.

“No, you are not,” said Frances.

Arthur bent over her. His watch chain hung away from his waistcoat. She looked at it instead of his face. There was the little gold seal she had given him when Edmund was born; there was the worn patch on the silk beneath it which his tailor had failed to notice. Fifteen years of marriage, represented by an abrasion.

“Can you sit?” the officer asked.

She knew him. The conviction arrived stupidly late, after her body had already made its declaration.

Charles Lightoller looked older than the man she had remembered and younger than the age he must have reached. He had the eyes she knew, set now in a face that weather had pared rather than spoiled. He did not look astonished. Perhaps officers were trained to receive the past without visible disturbance, as they received a report of damage below the waterline.

“Mrs Agner,” Arthur said. “My wife. She is not usually subject to these attacks.”

No, she thought. She had managed twenty years without one.

“Lightoller,” the officer said. “Second officer.”

He spoke to Arthur, but his hand supported her shoulder. Through wool and linen she felt the place precisely. Once, in a different century, that hand had closed around the back of her neck beneath her hair.

Frances saw her looking at him. Lorraine turned her head too quickly and the sky emptied again.

“Easy,” he said.

There had been a quay, and wet ropes, and a bell striking somewhere behind a wall of rain. She had been twenty-one. Nobody on the quay had called her Mrs Agner.

They raised her. She disliked how little she could contribute. Arthur took one arm and Lightoller the other, and for a few steps she travelled between the two arrangements she had made for her life. One had been approved by her father. The other had not.

A deck chair was produced. A rug appeared over her knees. The ship possessed, apparently, an inexhaustible supply of objects intended to prevent a person from feeling the world. Someone offered smelling salts, which she refused so sharply that Edmund laughed, then caught himself.

“Mother, you went absolutely white.”

“Edmund.”

“I mean before. Now you are rather green.”

Frances said, “Go and see where the steward has put her bag.”

Her brother went. He would forgive a command from Frances if it gave him an errand.

Arthur was asking about the doctor. Lightoller answered with economy. There was nothing furtive in his manner. She had not expected furtiveness; she had not expected him at all. Of all the ships crossing all the water in the world, her husband had booked passages on this one. He had called it an opportunity. She had consented because Frances wanted to see New York and Edmund wanted to see machinery, and

because Arthur had spent the winter getting up from dinner to attend to his correspondence.

“Some air,” she said. “I only wanted some air.”

“You have it,” Arthur said gently.

It was the gentleness that distressed her. A sharp husband would have given her somewhere to put her resentment.

Lightoller straightened. He had duties. She could see him recovering them, one by one, as a man gathered tools.

“Mrs Agner.”

He inclined his head. Nothing more. He was already withdrawing when she said, “Thank you, Mr Lightoller.”

His surname tasted unfamiliar spoken with its proper distance. She had once expected to own it.

He paused a fraction, not long enough for anyone to accuse him of it, and went on.

II

The doctor asked what she had eaten. This seemed to Lorraine both an intimate question and an inadequate one.

Breakfast, she said. Toast. Coffee. Some egg, perhaps.

Perhaps was not satisfactory. He asked whether she had slept, whether she had suffered palpitations before, whether she had recently been troubled by distress. Arthur answered the last question for her. They had had an excellent crossing so far. They had boarded at Southampton; the children had settled admirably; Mrs Agner had been looking forward to the voyage.

The doctor waited for Lorraine.

“A little excitement,” she said.

He found nothing immediately alarming. She was to rest, take something light, avoid becoming chilled. If the dizziness returned, she was to send for him. The large new ship continued to carry them west while he gave these small instructions. At home she might have believed that instructions could keep a person safe.

When he had gone, Arthur stood by the sitting-room table and turned her handbag over in his hands.

“Was it the crowd?”

“No.”

“Would you prefer to remain here this afternoon?”

“No.”

He put the bag down exactly within the edge of the table. Arthur dealt in imported timber, and had inherited from his trade a reverence for surfaces. Even when he was unhappy he did not set a wet glass on wood.

Frances had taken Edmund away to luncheon. The girl had proposed it herself. She was fifteen and had recently begun to have the alarming good manners of an adult who understood more than she chose to say.

“Do you know him?” Arthur asked.

Lorraine looked towards the door.

“The officer,” he said.

“Yes.”

The word cost less than she had expected. It had no explanation attached to it, and for a moment she enjoyed its nakedness.

“You might have said.”

“I have said.”

He drew out a chair but did not sit. There was a little grey at his temples now. She had not married a grey man. She had married a young one with a carefully trimmed moustache and a nervous way of taking money from his pocket, as if he expected somebody to dispute his ownership.

“An old family acquaintance?”

She considered accepting the phrase. Arthur had offered it to her as he might offer his arm at a difficult crossing.

“We were engaged.”

He sat down.

Outside the cabin, somebody laughed. The laugh passed their door and was diminished by distance. Lorraine noticed that one of her gloves lay palm upward on the carpet.

“When?”

“Before I knew you.”

“I assumed that.”

“Twenty years ago. Nearly.”

His glance moved to her left hand. It was an involuntary action, and she wished he had not done it. Her wedding ring had become so much a part of her hand that a second ring, an earlier one, seemed to belong to another woman's finger.

“Your father did not mention him.”

“My father did not approve.”

“Of the man?”

“Of the sea. Of uncertainty. Of his having no money. You may choose whichever explanation most flatters my father.”

Arthur did not answer. Her father was dead, and his prejudices had become family anecdotes. The living were expected to find them charming. Arthur had paid for the headstone.

“I ought to have told you,” she said.

“Before today?”

“Yes.”

He folded his hands. She remembered how patiently he had waited outside the room where Frances was being born. Afterwards the nurse had said that Mr Agner had not once asked how much longer it would take. Lorraine had kept that fact as a kind of treasure: he had understood that her labour did not inconvenience him.

“Is that why you fainted?”

“I think so.”

“You think so.”

“I did not arrange an explanation beforehand, Arthur.”

He winced. She had meant to strike the question, not the man.

“I am sorry.”

“Were you badly treated?”

It was so like him that she almost wept. He had found an injury he might be able to understand, perhaps even redress.

“No,” she said. Then, because the years had not made it simple: “Not in the way you mean.”

He rose. He would have liked to question her further; she could see him restraining himself, treating her illness as a temporary privilege which he must not violate.

“I shall have something sent in.”

“I could come to luncheon.”

“You could. But I think we should both prefer that you did not.”

After he left she picked up her glove. Dust clung to the stitching at the wrist. She brushed it with her thumb and sat on the edge of the bed.

For years she had described her former life to herself as a room which had been closed. She had even admired her own discretion in leaving it shut. Now she saw that she had merely put other people's furniture before the door.

She had not asked Arthur to marry an ignorant woman. Yet she had allowed him to marry an invented one: a girl who had been reasonably happy, reasonably innocent, waiting for him in her father's house.

The steward brought broth. She ate it because someone had killed an animal and warmed a bowl, and she could not bear another kindness being wasted.

III

In Liverpool the rain had worked its way into everything, including her father's accounts. The edges of the ledgers swelled in winter. Men came into the office with their hats dripping and wiped their hands before touching money, as though money were more delicate than paper.

Her father supplied provisions to ships. It had never occurred to Lorraine, as a girl, that there was irony in his abhorrence of sailors as husbands. Ships paid for the piano on which she practised and the silk she wore on Sundays. A

sailor entering the family would have been, he said, a different matter.

Charles had come to the house with a man her father knew. She could no longer remember the man's name. He had performed the service for which her memory required him and been dismissed from it.

Charles had not told sea stories at dinner. That was the first thing she had liked. The other young men who came had stories ready, like coins on a counter, and waited to see what they could purchase. He answered questions when he was asked, listened to her mother, and looked at the cracked glass of a picture over the sideboard.

Afterwards he told Lorraine that the crack resembled a coastline.

“Which one?” she had asked.

“An undiscovered one.”

She had decided this was wit. Perhaps it had been. She had been generous with the gifts she attributed to him.

He was a little younger than she was, though she had never admitted that this mattered. His youth was different from hers. He had been hungry, afraid, wet through in places whose names she could barely pronounce. She had been protected from a draught by a servant closing a door. When he spoke of waiting for work, she heard freedom. Later she wondered what he had heard when she spoke of wanting it.

They met first with permission, then without it. Their Liverpool was made from narrow allotments of time: an hour after a visit, twenty minutes before she must be home, a walk prolonged by pretending to mistake a turning. She grew expert in the smallest lies. Her mother was better

after breakfast; the seamstress had kept her; a book had not been available at the first shop.

She had thought lying would alter her face. Instead it made her attentive. She noticed who watched windows, which servant was likely to carry a message, how early her father returned on Thursdays. Love, which books had described as a species of blindness, taught her to see.

Charles kissed her beside a warehouse wall that had retained the day's meagre warmth. A cart went by. The horse had a white splash above one eye, and the driver never looked at them. She remembered being offended. Something had occurred which ought to have changed the movement of traffic.

He asked her to marry him without a ring. He had a small sum put by, less than her father spent on wine in a season, but it seemed to her that a man offering all his money could not be called poor.

“We shall have to wait,” he said.

“I can wait.”

She had been proud of that answer. At twenty-one she confused an absence of information with courage.

Her father received the news in his office, standing behind the desk. He did not shout. Shouting would have allowed the young lovers to believe themselves persecuted by a vulgar man.

“What will you live on?” he asked.

Charles answered. Her father asked again, having apparently heard nothing.

“What will she live on when you are away?”

That question was addressed to Charles also, though Lorraine was in the room and had begun to earn a small amount by giving music lessons. Her father would not admit those earnings as evidence. They were pin money when she possessed them, and proof of deprivation when she proposed living on them.

After Charles had gone, her father sat down. He looked tired, which she resented more than anger.

“He will always have somewhere else to be.”

“So do your ships.”

“My ships are not my family.”

She had thought that a monstrous answer. Now, sitting aboard one, she could remember how much it had frightened her.

There was a ring eventually, modest enough to turn the stone inward in the street. She wore it on a ribbon when she was at home. There were letters, some arriving in bunches, some so late that the emotion which produced them had travelled into another season. He wrote of work and weather, of men she did not know. At the bottom he wrote what she read first.

Then her mother became ill.

Illness changed the proportions of the house. The hall grew immense at night. The distance from bed to washstand could defeat a grown woman. Lorraine's father, who knew the price of flour by the ton, could not be trusted to measure a draught from a bottle.

A departure was proposed, then postponed. Charles wanted her to come away with him when circumstances allowed. Her father wanted her to remain until

circumstances improved. Each man described the future as something temporarily detained.

She wrote Charles a letter asking for a date, a plan, something definite she could put against the indefinite labour of staying.

He replied that he could not promise what he did not yet possess.

She had kept that sentence for twenty years as evidence against him. Only this morning had she begun to hear the care in it.

IV

Frances returned without knocking, then stopped and knocked against the open door.

“May I come in?”

“You appear to have done so.”

Her daughter closed it behind her. She had a plate with two little cakes on it and a folded napkin over her wrist. The performance of being grown up was spoiled by her uncertainty about where to put the plate.

“For you,” she said.

“Thank you.”

“Papa said you had broth. That is hardly food.”

“It is a very old form of food.”

Frances put the cakes beside the bowl. She remained standing. Her hair had escaped at the nape, the same brown as Lorraine's before its first white threads. People said that they looked alike when they wished to flatter the mother. In

fact Frances looked more like Arthur's sister, a woman who had never forgiven Lorraine for having better teeth.

“Where is Edmund?”

“Finding out something. I left him asking a steward a question the steward could not possibly answer.”

“What question?”

“How many revolutions the engines had made since Southampton.”

“He might have calculated it.”

“He wanted an exact number.”

Lorraine smiled. Frances did not.

“Did that officer hurt you?”

“No.”

“When you fell, I mean.”

“No, Frances.”

Her daughter sat in the chair Arthur had used. She inspected a loose thread on her cuff and pulled it until Lorraine wanted to tell her to stop. She did not tell her. A silence which belonged to someone else was hard to leave alone.

“You said his name,” Frances said.

“Your father introduced him.”

“Before that. You said Charles.”

Lorraine had not known. She had imagined consciousness as a door she could close, forgetting that sounds might pass underneath it.

“I knew him when I was young.”

“How young?”

“A little older than you.”

Frances considered this. At fifteen, all the ages above twenty formed a compact and uninteresting province.

“Was he in love with you?”

“That is not a question you should ask.”

“But it is the question.”

Outside, a trolley passed with the soft percussion of china. Lorraine looked at the cakes. One had a glazed cherry sunk in its centre. She used to give Frances cherries from her own plate when the child was small, and Arthur had once said she should not teach her to expect the best part of everything.

“Yes,” Lorraine said. “And I was in love with him.”

Frances's hand stopped worrying the thread.

“Does Papa know?”

“He knows we were engaged.”

“Engaged!”

“Quietly, if you please.”

Her daughter stared at her with an interest Lorraine had not inspired for years. She found it humiliating that she must have suffered before motherhood to become a person.

“Why did you not marry?”

“We could not agree on how to do it.”

“That sounds absurd.”

“It is very common.”

“But if you loved each other—”

“Yes,” Lorraine said. “That was our opinion too.”

Frances rose and went to the small mirror. She did not look into it. She touched a bottle on the shelf, moved it a little, then put it back. Her mother recognised an occupation invented to conceal a thought.

“What is it?”

“Nothing.”

“Very well.”

She waited. Frances turned.

“Miss Bell said that after Easter I might try the examination. For the school in London. She said there was no reason I should not have proper instruction.”

“Your father has not refused.”

“You said he would not like me living away.”

“I said he would wish to consider it.”

“You said we should see after the voyage. That is how you say no when you do not wish to be heard saying it.”

Lorraine looked down at her hands. So the girl had been listening all these years. One brought up children to speak truthfully and then was appalled by the uses they found for the skill.

“It would be a considerable change.”

“For me,” Frances said.

“For all of us.”

“But mostly for me.”

She had Arthur's eyes. Lorraine had always thought them mild in her husband's face; in Frances's they could be pitiless.

“I shall speak to your father.”

“I could speak to him myself.”

“Yes,” Lorraine said, before she could improve the answer into something less generous. “You could.”

Frances looked surprised, then suspicious. She had expected resistance and did not trust its withdrawal.

“Not today,” Lorraine added. “He has had enough to consider.”

Her daughter nodded. At the door she turned back.

“Are you sorry?”

Lorraine could have pretended to misunderstand.

“About some things.”

“About Papa?”

“No.”

She said it firmly enough to frighten them both. Frances left, taking the empty bowl but leaving the cakes. Lorraine broke one in half. It was dry and sweeter than she wanted. She ate it slowly, accepting that her daughter had brought what she believed would help.

V

In the afternoon Lorraine put on a different hat.

The first had been damaged at the brim. The maid offered to do something with it, and Lorraine said there was no hurry. She could not bear to have the morning repaired so quickly.

She told Arthur she meant to walk. He was reading a newspaper whose news was already old. At sea information aged differently; the paper spoke with confidence of matters which might have been settled or overturned since it was printed.

“Shall I accompany you?”

“If you would like.”

“That is not what I asked.”

“No.”

He lowered the paper.

“I should like a little time alone,” she said.

“Will you be sensible?”

“I hope not exclusively.”

A smile almost came to him. He restrained it, and she did not blame him.

She took the covered promenade at a measured pace. Other passengers had occupied the chairs as though they had brought them from home. A woman with violets on her hat was reading a letter and moving her lips. Two men discussed a senator. The ship's steady movement passed through the deck into Lorraine's feet, too large and regular to be mistaken for her own pulse.

She did not know where officers went when they were not visible. In memory Charles belonged to quays, streets, the corner of a room after dinner. Here he belonged to an organisation of passages and ladders which she was neither entitled nor equipped to enter.

A steward asked if he could help her. She almost said no.

“Would it be possible to leave a note for Mr Lightoller?”

“Certainly, madam.”

The readiness of the answer disconcerted her. She had expected the world to defend her against herself.

At a writing table she began, Dear Charles, and looked at the words until they became intolerable. She tore the sheet

once and folded the pieces together. The second began, Mr Lightoller.

She wished to thank him for his assistance, she wrote. If his duties permitted, she would be walking after four. She signed Lorraine Agner, giving him the full possession of her married name.

Then she went back to Arthur.

“I have asked if I may speak to him.”

Her husband laid down his newspaper. He had not turned many pages.

“Why?”

“Because I should prefer a conversation to another twenty years of imagining one.”

“Does he deserve that consideration?”

“I think I do.”

Arthur looked away. She had never seen him refuse a fact so quietly.

“Very well,” he said.

She stood by the table. There was no gracious way to leave a man after asking his permission to hurt him.

“I am not asking you to approve.”

“No. You are asking me to behave well.”

She could not answer.

“I shall try,” he said.

At four she was on deck. By a quarter past she had become conscious of every passer-by. She wished she had specified a place. A ship advertised as immense was proving unexpectedly small in the regions where a woman could wait without explanation.

He came when she had begun to hope he would not.

“Mrs Agner.”

“Mr Lightoller.”

He removed his cap briefly. She could see the line where it had pressed his hair.

“You have recovered?”

“Yes. I am sorry to have interfered with your duties.”

“It was not your choice.”

They stood near a vacant chair. She had thought she would sit, but to sit would require him to bend towards her, and she wanted them on equal terms if equal terms could be arranged.

“My husband knows,” she said.

Charles looked at her then, fully.

“About us,” she added, and disliked the satisfaction the small pronoun gave her.

“I see.”

“He knows that we were engaged. He did not know before this morning.”

The ship moved through a long, shallow swell. Far below, water was broken and remade against the hull.

“I did not recognise you at once,” Charles said.

“No?”

“I saw a lady who was unwell. Then I heard your daughter say your name.”

That was better than a compliment and worse than an insult. She had been lying on the deck, giving herself back to a passion; he had been attending to a passenger.

“You have a daughter,” he said.

“And a son.”

“Yes. He asked whether you had cracked your skull.”

“That would be Edmund.”

Charles smiled. The smile was still capable of doing her harm, but not the same harm. It was no longer a promise made especially to her.

“I have children too,” he said.

“I supposed you might.”

She had supposed many things, not one of them in sufficient detail to admit a wife tying a child's bootlace, a bill arriving, a room being kept warm. She had allowed him adventures and weather and perhaps occasional loneliness. She had not allowed him Tuesday.

“My wife is called Sylvia.”

Lorraine nodded.

“She is not aboard.”

“No.”

The answer had not been necessary. Neither of them could now put it back.

VI

“I sent you a letter,” Lorraine said.

He was silent long enough for her to understand that there had been more than one letter, and that he must decide which she meant.

“The last one.”

“Yes.”

“You received it?”

“Yes.”

The answer disappointed her. For years she had left a narrow place in her account of the past where a lost letter might fit. Letters were lost. Ships carried them into storms; clerks misread names. An accident could have preserved both their innocence.

“Then you knew why I wrote it.”

“I knew what you said.”

She had written that she released him from his promise. A noble phrase, borrowed from a novel and made shabby by use. She had written that he must not consider himself bound to a woman who could offer him only complications. She had written that she would not answer if he replied.

What she had meant was: come to the house. Stand at the door. Make it impossible for me to send you away.

“I was waiting for you,” she said.

His face changed, not with revelation but with effort.

“You told me not to come.”

“I know what I told you.”

“I had to take it seriously.”

“Did you?”

He looked past her towards the end of the promenade, then back. She had driven him, in less than five minutes, to the edge of impatience.

“What would you have had me do?”

The question had been her property for twenty years. Hearing it from him felt almost like theft.

“My mother was dying.”

“I knew.”

“My father said if I left, I should not come back. He said she would ask for me and he would tell her where I had gone.”

Charles's mouth tightened.

“You did not put that in the letter.”

“I could not put everything in it.”

“No.”

She had intended this meeting as a retrieval. A missing explanation would be found, polished, set in its place. Instead each fact brought another with it, until she could scarcely hold what she had carried here.

“I thought,” she said, “that if you wanted me sufficiently, you would know.”

He leaned one hand on the back of the chair. The glove with the missing button had been replaced, or mended. She could not tell.

“I was young,” he said. “I was angry. I thought you had chosen your father.”

“So you let me.”

“Yes.”

It was the first unprotected answer he had given her.

A man passed with a little girl holding two fingers of his hand. The child was counting something along the deck. Charles waited until they were beyond hearing.

“I could say I respected your decision,” he said. “I did, in part. But there was pride in it. I will not dress that up.”

She looked down. The boards had been scrubbed to a pale, almost domestic cleanness. At her father's house the

kitchen floor had smelled of soap on Saturday afternoons. Her mother had died on a Saturday, while downstairs the maid carried on scrubbing because nobody had told her to stop.

“I wanted you to rescue me,” Lorraine said.

“From them?”

“From having to decide.”

He did not answer quickly. She was grateful for that.

“I doubt I should have done it well.”

“You might have.”

“I might.”

They were generous at last, now that generosity could alter nothing.

“I married in ninety-six,” she said. “Arthur had been calling for some time. He was kind to my father after my mother died. Everybody said that was evidence of a good nature.”

“Was it?”

“Yes. It was.”

She had not expected to defend her husband to the man she had once meant to marry. Charles had not required the defence. That made it necessary in another way.

“Are you happy?” he asked.

She almost laughed. They had arrived at the question printed at the end of every cheap romance, as though happiness were a railway station and one could give a simple account of reaching it.

“Sometimes. Often. I have not made it my practice to count.”

“That sounds sensible.”

“It is not always a recommendation.”

He smiled slightly, but his attention had begun to divide. A figure at the far end of the deck had glanced towards him twice. She saw the officer returning, not rudely, but necessarily. The man she had kept for herself was employed by other people.

“There is something I should tell you,” she said.

He waited.

“I used to think that you had taken the part of my life which would have been different.”

“And now?”

“Now I think I gave it to you to look after. Without asking whether you wanted it.”

He considered her with a seriousness that was more intimate than pity.

“I should not have known where to keep it.”

She laughed then. It escaped her before she could judge whether laughter was permitted, and he laughed too, briefly. For that moment they were not young again. They were two people old enough to hear the absurdity in what they had suffered.

“I must go,” he said.

“Yes.”

“If you feel unwell again, please send for the doctor. Not merely a steward.”

“I shall try to faint less dramatically.”

“Try not to faint at all.”

He put on his cap. She could have asked to see him again. The opening was there, small but sufficient; he had not stepped away. She felt its shape and let it remain empty.

“Good afternoon, Mrs Agner.”

“Good afternoon.”

He walked back to his work. She watched until the watching became a choice, and then turned towards the water.

VII

Edmund found her before she was ready to be found. He had a notebook in his hand and a smudge on his chin whose origin she preferred not to investigate.

“Have you been crying?”

“The wind.”

“There is not very much.”

“There is enough.”

He accepted that. Adults were entitled, in his estimation, to a reasonable number of unsatisfactory answers, provided they did not obstruct an investigation.

“I have been looking for you.”

“Is something wrong?”

“No. I wanted to know whether you wanted to see what I have done.”

She had said no that morning, before the encounter, when he wanted her to inspect a drawing. Or she had said later, which Frances had correctly identified as a form of no. Now she held out her hand.

He sat beside her and opened the notebook. He had drawn the ship from memory, assisted by a small printed picture acquired somewhere. The funnels were too tall and the stern had an uncertain droop. Beneath the drawing he had begun a list of dimensions.

“This is not quite right,” he said, pointing to an arrangement of lines.

“It looks very fine.”

“That is not the same thing.”

“No,” she said. “It is not.”

He explained the error. She attended as carefully as she could, which was not carefully enough, but he seemed pleased by the effort. He had also drawn a cross-section of an engine he had not seen, constructing it from an explanation delivered by a man who might not have seen it either.

“Perhaps you should put a question mark there,” she said.

“I cannot put question marks everywhere.”

“Why not?”

“Then it would not be a drawing. It would only be questions.”

She returned the notebook.

“Your sister tells me you have been interrogating the staff.”

“Only when they were not busy.”

“How could you tell?”

“If they were standing still.”

She made a mental note to leave something for the stewards at the end of the voyage.

“Did you thank the officer?” Edmund asked.

“Yes.”

“He was very quick. I did not know you could catch a person that quickly.”

“He has had practice with difficult things.”

“Do you know him?”

“Yes. From a long time ago.”

“Before Papa?”

“Yes.”

He looked interested, though not in the way his sister had.

“Was he always a sailor?”

“Nearly always, I think.”

“How splendid.”

She watched her son's face. There was an age at which departures were pure gain, at which the world contained no one whose absence could outweigh the pleasure of going. She did not wish to hurry him beyond it. Neither did she wish to stand at its gate with her father's ledger.

“Would you like that?” she asked.

“Going to sea?”

“Yes.”

He considered. “Perhaps. Or building things. I should like to know how they are made before I decide.”

“That seems wise.”

“Papa says there will be work in the business.”

“There may be.”

“But he does not know whether I shall be good at it.”

“No.”

“He thinks because I can add up.”

“Your father knows more about you than that.”

Edmund bent the corner of a page, then smoothed it with his nail.

“Do you think he will be disappointed?”

“I think your father will survive a disappointment.”

She had spoken more to herself than to the boy. He looked relieved, then immediately anxious at having been given so much freedom.

“I have not decided.”

“Nobody is requiring you to decide this afternoon.”

They sat for a little without speaking. Edmund's legs were beginning to grow faster than the rest of him; his trousers exposed a strip of sock. She would need to have them altered when they reached New York. The thought came with the consoling force of a duty that could actually be performed.

He went to find his father. Before he left, he put his hand awkwardly on her shoulder.

“You should have said if you were going to fall.”

“I did not know.”

“Next time,” he said, already halfway turned away, “try to know.”

She watched him go. Her children were asking very reasonable things of her. Tell them before she fell. Let them speak. Admit what she did not know.

A bell sounded somewhere aboard. She could not have said what it marked. The ship was ordered by hours and watches which continued whether she understood them or not. For once she found no humiliation in that. She rose, taking care to establish her balance before she walked.

VIII

Arthur was changing for dinner when she returned. His coat lay across a chair, and the white ends of his tie hung loose against his shirt. Without the coat he looked less substantial, a man assembled each morning from a number of respectable parts.

He saw her in the mirror.

“Did you speak?”

“Yes.”

“Are you better for it?”

“I do not know yet.”

He turned from the mirror. “At least that is an answer I can believe.”

She took off her hat. A pin caught and pulled at her hair. Arthur made a movement towards her, then stopped, as though he no longer knew which small services were his to perform.

“Will you help?” she asked.

He freed the pin. She set the hat on the dressing table.

“He received my last letter,” she said. “I had wondered whether he had.”

Arthur held the pin between finger and thumb.

“You have wondered all this time?”

“Not every day.”

“But while we were married.”

“Yes.”

He put the pin down.

“Lorraine, I cannot argue with a man who was never here.”

“I know.”

“No, I do not think you do. If he had been here, I might have disliked him. I might have seen some fault you could see too. But you have had him safely elsewhere, doing everything I failed to do.”

She sat down. She had expected jealousy to be foolish, and his was not.

“I did not think of it like that.”

“How did you think of it?”

“As something that happened to me.”

“And did not happen to anyone else.”

She looked at him. His anger was quiet, but it had passed beyond courtesy. She did not remember ever being so attentive to him.

“I was afraid to tell you,” she said.

“When?”

“At first, because I thought you would withdraw. Later, because you had not.”

He stood beside the chair with his hands resting on its back. The pose reminded her unexpectedly of Charles on deck. Men supported themselves on furniture when women made revelations. She wondered how many rooms had witnessed it.

“Did you love me when we married?”

She had feared that question all afternoon. Now that it was spoken she discovered that the answer had changed while she feared it.

“Not as you deserved.”

“That is charitable. To whom, I am not sure.”

“I wanted to love you. I liked being with you. I trusted you. I thought love would follow if I did everything properly.”

“And did it?”

“Yes.”

He looked at her without moving.

“Not because I did things properly,” she said. “I was wrong about that.”

He sat on the edge of the bed. For years she had seen him tired, worried, absorbed in calculations; she had not often seen him uncertain of his welcome.

“When Frances had the fever,” she said, “you came home with oranges.”

“The doctor said she might take the juice.”

“You had gone to three shops.”

“Four.”

“She would not have any. She wanted you to peel them in one piece. You sat there for an hour, getting it wrong.”

“I remember.”

“I loved you then.”

His face did not soften in the way she had hoped. She understood: a man should not have to bring his evidence to his own wife.

“I cannot offer you one occasion as an answer,” she said. “There were others. There were mornings when you were only eating your breakfast. I have been careless with what did not threaten to leave me.”

He lowered his head.

She could have touched him. Instead she waited, allowing him the privacy of a feeling she had caused. The engine's movement was faintly perceptible through the soles of her feet. Somewhere beyond the wall a drawer was opened and shut.

“Do you wish you had married him?” Arthur asked.

“I wish I had not made my father's wishes an excuse for failing to make my own. That is not quite the same thing.”

“It may be a distinction easier for you than for me.”

“Yes.”

“And if he had asked you today?”

“He would not.”

“If he had.”

She looked at the open collar of his shirt, at the skin her children had kissed, the small old burn on his wrist where he had once upset a spirit lamp.

“No,” she said. “I would not go.”

He let out a breath. She had not realised he was holding it.

“That does not put everything right,” he said.

“No.”

“I shall probably be disagreeable tomorrow.”

“You may begin tonight, if you prefer.”

He almost smiled, then did smile, unwillingly. She had not earned it. She would have to remember that.

She rose to ring for help with her dress, but stopped beside him.

“Frances wishes to try the examination for the school in London.”

He looked up, astonished by the change of subject.

“Does she?”

“Yes. She should tell you herself. I have been putting her off.”

“Why?”

“Because I shall miss her.”

He considered that.

“So shall I,” he said.

They were silent. Then he reached for his tie.

“Missing her is not a reason,” he said.

“No.”

She took the ends of the tie from his hands. He allowed it. Her fingers made the familiar folds, loosened them, began again. He had always been patient with the small delay this caused, though he could tie it more quickly himself.

At dinner Frances watched them both. Edmund described his drawing and was corrected, with unexpected precision, by his father. Lorraine ate more than she wanted because everyone had acquired an interest in the contents of her plate. The conversation moved cautiously at first, then gathered enough ordinary weight to proceed without assistance.

Afterwards Frances asked Arthur whether they might talk in the morning. He said they might. She glanced at Lorraine, who did not look away.

Much later, when the children had gone to bed, Lorraine stood for a moment beside the dark glass of a window. It gave her back a woman in an evening dress, the line of her shoulder, a little brightness at her throat. Beyond the reflection she could see almost nothing.

She had brought no old letters aboard. They were in a box at home beneath a piece of lace which had belonged to her mother. She had once imagined burning them as the final act of a recovered heart. Now she thought she might simply read them again. There would be things in them she had not noticed, weather she had skipped, work she had mistaken for an obstacle placed between herself and love.

Arthur came to stand beside her. He did not put his arm around her. In the glass their reflections occupied separate patches of light.

“Are you coming?” he asked.

“In a moment.”

He nodded and waited.

She turned from the window before the moment had quite elapsed. When they reached their door, she took the key from him and opened it herself.

Historical Note

This story is fiction. Lorraine, Arthur, Frances and Edmund Agner are invented, as are Lorraine's engagement to Charles Lightoller, their earlier correspondence and every private conversation depicted here. Charles Herbert Lightoller was Titanic's second officer and was married to Sylvia Hawley-Wilson, whom he married in 1903. Titanic sailed from Southampton on 10 April 1912 and was westbound in the Atlantic on 12 April, after leaving Queenstown on 11 April. The story ends on 12 April; the ship's collision and sinking occurred later, on the night of 14–15 April. No claim is made that Lightoller had the romantic history imagined here.

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